QP Code 25900860

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM MIGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR /IMPROVEMENT/REAPPEARANCE EXAMINATION NOVEMBER 2025
FIRST SEMESTER
Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG1MDCHIS100 - FLAVOURS OF THE PAST AND PRESENT : FOOD, CULTURE AND SOCIETY (2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1.5 Hours
Maximum Marks: 50
Remember(K), Understand(U), Apply(A), Analyse(An), Evaluate(E), Create(C), Skill(S), Interest(I) and Appreciation(Ap)

Students should attempt at least one question from each course outcome to enhance their overall outcome attainability

Part A
Short Answer Type Questions. Answer any 5 out of 8 Questions. Each Question carries 2 marks

1. What were the major crops, spices and vegetables grown in ancient India?
- Cereals: Barley (Yava) and Wheat were primary in the Vedic period; Rice (Vrihi) became dominant later.
- Spices: Black pepper, cardamom, ginger, turmeric, and long pepper (Pippali).
- Vegetables: Pumpkin, gourd, cucumber, and various leafy greens.
- Crops like potatoes, tomatoes, and chillies were not present (they arrived later with the Portuguese).

2. Explain the different theories regarding the agriculture and diet of early human civilization.
- Neolithic Revolution: The shift from hunter-gatherer lifestyles to settled farming and animal domestication.
- Surplus Theory: The idea that agriculture created food surpluses, which allowed populations to grow and led to the development of cities and civilization.
- Dietary Shift: The transition from a diverse, high-protein wild diet to a high-carbohydrate, grain-heavy diet (which initially reduced average height and health but sustained larger populations).

3. How did the Portuguese introduce new food items to India, and what are some examples?
- The Columbian Exchange: The Portuguese brought crops native to the "New World" (Americas) to India via their trade routes.
- Examples: Chilies (which replaced pepper for heat), Potatoes, Tomatoes, Pineapples, Papayas, Cashew nuts, and Guava.
- Culinary Influence: They also introduced vinegar-based cooking (e.g., Vindaloo) and baking techniques (bread/pav).

4. How did the British popularize tea and coffee in India?
- Plantations: They established large-scale tea gardens (e.g., in Assam, Darjeeling, Nilgiris) to break the Chinese monopoly on tea.
- Railway Marketing: The Tea Board set up tea stalls at railway stations to offer cheap, accessible tea to travelers, creating a habit.
- Workplace Rituals: They introduced "tea breaks" in factories and offices to boost worker energy with sugar and caffeine.

5. What role did the British play in popularizing tea and coffee in India?
- Commercialization: They transformed tea and coffee from medicinal/elite drinks into mass-market commodities.
- Cultural Integration: They marketed tea as a "Swadeshi" (local) product eventually, despite its colonial origins, embedding it into Indian hospitality culture.

6. How has the visual culture of food changed in India with globalization?
- Food Pornography: The rise of social media (Instagram/YouTube) where the look of the food (plating, colors) is prioritized over taste.

- Packaging: A shift from traditional loose selling to attractive, Western-style branded packaging.
- Entertainment: Food shows (like MasterChef) turning cooking into a visual spectacle and a lifestyle aspiration rather than just a domestic chore.

7. What are some of the popular food taboos and their origins in India?

- Beef: Taboo in Hinduism due to the religious sanctity and economic importance of the cow (Cow is treated as Sacred to Hindu community).
- Pork: Strictly forbidden (Haram) in Islam.
- Caste-based Restrictions (Commensality): Historical rules regarding who could cook for whom (purity/pollution concepts) to maintain caste hierarchies.
- Onion/Garlic: Avoided in Jainism and by some Hindu communities for being "tamasic" or stimulating, which is believed to hinder meditation.

8. How has the perception of alcohol changed over time?

- Ancient/Vedic: Used in rituals (Soma) but often viewed with caution in daily social life (Surapana).
- Colonial Period: Standardized as a source of state revenue (excise tax) and became a social habit among the elite.
- Modern Day: A dual perception exists—it is seen by some as a "social evil" (leading to prohibition in states like Gujarat/Bihar) and by others as a symbol of cosmopolitan status and relaxation.

Part B

Short Essay Type Questions. Answer any 4 out of 7 Questions. Each Question carries 5 marks

9. In what ways do early Indian texts reflect the importance of food in religious and ritual practices?

- Vedic Texts: Mention of Soma and Madhu as divine offerings. Agni (fire) is described as the mouth of the gods through which food oblations (Ghee/Grains) are received.
- Upanishads: The Taittiriya Upanishad famously declares "Annam Brahma" (Food is God) and describes the cycle of life as dependent on food.
- Ayurveda: Texts like Charaka Samhita classify food not just by taste but by its spiritual effect on the mind (Sattvic for purity, Rajasic for passion, Tamasic for lethargy).
- Purity & Pollution: Dharmashastras outline strict rules on who can prepare food and who can eat it (commensality) to maintain ritual purity.
- Prasadam: The concept that food offered to the deity is sanctified and becomes a blessing for the devotee.

10. In what ways did festivals and celebrations serve as a platform for the syncretic evolution of food traditions in pre-colonial India?

- Mughal-Hindu Interaction: Royal courts often celebrated festivals like Diwali and Holi, leading to a blending of Persian (meats, dried fruits) and Indian (dairy, sweets) culinary styles.
- Sufi Shrines (Dargahs): The tradition of Langar or Urs festivals where people of all faiths ate together, blending local regional tastes with Islamic meat/grain dishes (e.g., Haleem or Khichda).
- Harvest Festivals: Festivals like Onam, Pongal, or Baisakhi acted as community bonding events where rigid caste barriers were sometimes temporarily loosened through communal feasting.
- Exchange of Food: The tradition of exchanging sweets and dishes between Hindu, Muslim, and Christian neighbors during their respective festivals fostered cross-cultural appreciation of tastes.

11. How did the arrival of foreign traders and colonizers affect the spice trade and food culture in Kerala?

- Spice Trade Hub: Kerala’s "Black Gold" (Pepper) attracted Arabs, Chinese, Portuguese, and Dutch, turning the region into a global trade center.
- Arab Influence: Introduction of Mappila cuisine characteristics, such as the use of ghee, Biryani, and wheat-based breads like Pathiri.

- Portuguese Influence: Introduction of "New World" crops (Chili, Potato, Tomato, Cashew), the technique of using vinegar (essential for dishes like Vindaloo), and baking (bread/cakes).
- Chinese Influence: Likely introduction of Chinese fishing nets and the wok (Cheena-chatti).
- Economic Shift: A transition from subsistence farming to the cultivation of cash crops (spices) to meet European demand.

12. In what ways did sugar and chocolate become symbols of luxury and status in early Europe?

- Exclusivity & Cost: Initially, both were imported from colonies and were prohibitively expensive, affordable only to royalty and the aristocracy.
- Medicinal Origins: They were first treated as exotic medicines or tonics before evolving into recreational treats.
- Display of Wealth: Sugar was used to create elaborate sculptures ("subtleties") at royal banquets to display the host's power and wealth.
- Social Rituals: The establishment of "Chocolate Houses" in London and salons in Paris became elite gathering spots for the upper class to socialize and discuss politics.
- Gift offering: Sugar loaves and chocolate were often given as high-status diplomatic gifts.

13. How does the act of chewing, whether bubble gum or pan, serve as a means of stress relief or enjoyment in daily life?

- Stress Relief (Fidgeting): The repetitive mechanical action of chewing helps release tension and lower cortisol levels, acting as a "fidgeting" tool for the mouth.
- Social Lubricant (Paan): In India, chewing Paan is a communal activity, a sign of hospitality, and a way to bond after meals.
- Sensory Stimulation: Bubble gum provides sensory engagement through sweetness and flavor, which can alleviate boredom.
- Focus: Some studies suggest chewing gum can increase blood flow to the brain and improve concentration during repetitive tasks.
- Digestive Aid: Paan is culturally valued for its perceived digestive properties and use as a mouth freshener.

14. In what ways do cultural expectations shape men's and women's roles in the kitchen across different societies?

- Private vs. Public Sphere: Women are traditionally expected to manage the "private" domestic kitchen (unpaid labor/duty), while men often dominate the "public" commercial kitchen (Chefs/paid profession).
- Nurturer vs. Artist: A woman's cooking is often framed as "nurturing" or "caregiving," whereas a man's cooking is often framed as a "skill," "art," or for special occasions (like barbecuing).
- Childhood Conditioning: Toys (kitchen sets) are often marketed to girls, reinforcing the kitchen as a female domain from a young age.
- Patriarchy: In many cultures, the act of serving food is seen as a sign of submission or service, a role historically assigned to women.

15. In what ways has alcohol been integrated into religious rituals and celebrations throughout history?

- Christianity: Wine is central to the Eucharist/Communion, symbolizing the blood of Christ.
- Vedic Religion: Soma was a ritual drink offered to gods (Indra) and consumed by priests during sacrifices to induce a divine state.
- Tribal/Indigenous Faiths: Alcohol (like rice beer or palm wine) is often essential for offerings to ancestors and nature spirits to ensure protection and good harvest.
- Greco-Roman Mythology: Worship of Dionysus/Bacchus (gods of wine) involved festivals and ritual consumption of wine to achieve ecstasy.
- Social Celebrations: In secular contexts, alcohol (toasting) serves as a communal bond and social lubricant at weddings, victories, and festivals (e.g., Champagne celebrations).

Part C

Essay Type Questions. Answer any 2 out of 4 Questions. Each Question carries 10 marks

16. Discuss the ways in which Indian cuisine and beverage culture adapted to and influenced European culinary traditions.

- Overview of the Columbian Exchange and the colonial trade routes that facilitated a two-way cultural flow between India and Europe.-Influence of India on Europe (The "Curry" Phenomenon)-Spices: European exploration-Modern Impact: "Chicken Tikka Masala" is widely considered a British national dish; the proliferation of "Curry Houses" across the UK.-Beverages: The word "Punch" originated from the Hindi Paanch (five ingredients).-Influence of Europe on India (Adaptation)-New World Ingredients: The Portuguese introduced crops that are now Indian staples: Chilies (replacing pepper for heat), Potatoes, Tomatoes, Cashew nuts, and Papayas-Baking & Fermentation: Introduction of bread (Pav), biscuits, and cakes; use of vinegar in Goan cooking (e.g., Vindaloo)-Tea & Coffee Culture: The British commercialized tea production (Assam/Darjeeling), transforming it from a medicinal herb to India's national drink (Chai)-Dining Etiquette: The elite adoption of tables, chairs, porcelain, and cutlery (forks/spoons) over traditional floor seating and eating with hands.

17. In what ways did access to clubs and dining establishments in Kerala reflect social class dynamics in the 20th century?

- Dining spaces in Kerala were never neutral; they were markers of caste, colonial power, and later, economic class-Colonial Clubs:Establishments like the Cochin Club or Trivandrum Club were originally exclusive "Whites Only" spaces.They represented racial superiority and were centers of colonial administration and leisure.-Post-Colonial Elite (The "Brown Sahibs")-After independence, these clubs opened to Indian elites (bureaucrats, planters) but maintained exclusivity through high membership fees and strict dress codes (western attire).They served as status symbols, distinguishing the upper class from the common man.The Rise of Public Dining (Hotels & Teashops)-Caste Barriers: Early 20th-century eateries often had separate seating or utensils for different castes. Social reformers (like Sahodaran Ayyappan) used inter-dining to break these barriers.The "Chayakada" (Tea Shop): These became democratic spaces for the working class to read newspapers and discuss politics (Communism), playing a vital role in Kerala's political literacy.Contrast the exclusivity of the private club with the inclusivity of the teashop to show the spectrum of Kerala's social evolution.

18. How do religious beliefs influence vegetarianism in different cultures? Provide examples from Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism.

- Introduction: Religion is a primary driver of dietary ethics, particularly regarding the concept of violence and purity.Jainism (The Strictest Approach)-Concept: Ahimsa (non-violence) is the supreme duty.Practice: Strict lacto-vegetarianism- Salekhana and Santhara: Fasting unto death.Hinduism (Purity and Karma):Concept: Diet is linked to Gunas (Sattva, Rajas, Tamas). Vegetarian food is considered Sattvic (pure) and conducive to spiritual progress.Practice: Cow is sacred; beef is a major taboo.Vegetarianism is often caste-specific (Brahmins/Vaishnavas) or observed on specific holy days, rather than being universal.Buddhism (The Middle Path):The First Precept is to abstain from taking life.Practice: Monks generally follow a vegetarian diet, but views vary.In Theravada tradition, monks may eat meat if it is offered as alms and they did not see, hear, or suspect the animal was killed specifically for them. Mahayana traditions often advocate stricter vegetarianism based on compassion (Karuna).All the three advocate non-violence, the application varies from absolute restriction (Jainism) to spiritual purity (Hinduism) and intent-based ethics (Buddhism).

19. How did poverty pose a major challenge to developing nations?

- Defining poverty not just as a lack of income, but as food insecurity and lack of access to basic nutrition, which cripples national development.Health & Malnutrition-Stunting: Chronic hunger leads to physical and cognitive stunting in children, permanently affecting the nation's future human capital/workforce. "Hidden Hunger": Reliance on cheap staples (rice/wheat) without vegetables/protein leads to micronutrient deficiencies (anemia, etc.).Economic Vicious Cycle:Poor nutrition leads to poor health: low productivity-low income -continued poverty.The high percentage of income spent on food leaves little for education or healthcare.Vulnerability to Global Markets:Developing nations often rely on food imports.

Global price spikes can cause famine or civil unrest (food riots).Shift from subsistence farming to cash crops (for export) can reduce local food security.Poverty acts as a barrier to sustainable development, trapping nations in a cycle of hunger and low growth that requires systemic intervention.